

3.5 Unit 3, Topic C: Representative Processes in the USA

Focus This topic looks at the representative processes of the US political system and considers their adequacy in terms of popular participation and full democracy.

What students need to learn: ***Students taking Unit 3, Topic C must learn all areas within the topic.***

Elections and Voting

Key concepts	Content explanation
primary and caucus elections propositions partisanship invisible primaries national party conventions presidential debates congressional elections mid-term elections	■ A knowledge of the electoral mechanisms used in the US system and of their significance. ■ An awareness of the factors that explain the outcomes of recent presidential and congressional elections, including voting behaviour in recent elections and campaign finance.

Political Parties

Key concepts	Content explanation
party decline/renewal two-party system conservative liberalism	■ A knowledge of the ideologies, theories and traditions of the Democrats and Republicans, of conflicts and tendencies within each party, and of their coalitions of supporters. ■ A knowledge of the US party system, of the distribution of power within parties, and of the changing significance of parties as a means of organising the electorate and as channels of political access. ■ A knowledge of minor parties, their impact and obstacles to participation.

Pressure Groups

Key concepts	Content explanation
public interest groups private interest groups lobbying	■ A knowledge of the different categories of groups within the US system and of how they operate. ■ A knowledge of the policy significance of organised groups and interests, of their resources and tactics, and of debates about their impact upon democracy. ■ A knowledge of how they operate to influence specified branches of federal government as well as exploiting the electoral process to enhance their influence.

Racial and Ethnic Politics

Key concepts	Content explanation
civil rights multiculturalism/ multiracialism black nationalism ethnic coalitions and conflicts affirmative action	■ A knowledge of racial and ethnic diversity in the USA, of key issues in minority politics, including forms of minority political activism, the extent of minority representation and an evaluation of the policies to diminish racial division.